# DO FAULT ZONES ROUTE ROAD-SALT-CONTAMINATED GROUNDWATER TO STREAMS? A HUDSON VALLEY, NY CASE STUDY

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**ABSTRACT**

Streams in the northeastern United States have grown saltier as road salt applied in winter accumulates in groundwater and is released slowly, so stream salinity can stay high through summer baseflow. Where that stored salt re-emerges is poorly known. We asked whether high-angle geologic fault zones act as preferential conduits that route road-salt-contaminated groundwater from highways to streams, a linkage previously inferred only from groundwater wells. We surveyed specific conductance at roughly 100 m spacing (about 400 m at Site 2) along three reaches of Wappinger Creek, Dutchess County, New York, where mapped faults cross or run along the channel, and sampled one 2.35 km chloride transect in 2020. Zones were compared only within a single survey day, because the two Site 3 survey days differ by more than any contrast tested: pooled across days, the second Site 3 fault appears as an 18 $\mu$S/cm step, but within one day it is $+1.6$ $\mu$S/cm and not significant. Of three fault contrasts, one (Site 2, where the zone boundary is the fault position interpreted in the field at an abrupt 90° channel bend) showed a small, significant increase ($+4.3$ $\mu$S/cm, about 2.5 times instrument accuracy). Change-point analysis showed it to be a gradual rise beginning roughly 1.6 km upstream of the bend, not a step at it, and no conductance breakpoint on any transect coincided with a fault contrast boundary. A tributary contrast decreased conductance, as mixing predicts. The chloride peak lay near a different fault and rested on one sample. Road proximity, developed land, wastewater plants beside Site 2, salt stored in soils and diffuse groundwater remain plausible alternatives. This survey therefore does not clearly show fault-routed transport. We outline a test design: single-day or tie-pointed surveys, discharge measurements, chloride-to-bromide ratios, age tracers, cross-channel repeats, field-located faults and several lithologies.

***Keywords*** water quality · fault lines · salinity · de-icing · roadway management

## 1 Introduction

Road salt has been used as a de-icing agent in North America and Europe since the early 1940s, and its use has climbed steadily decade over decade [1, 2]. It is indispensable for winter road safety, but it also poses a widespread salinization threat to fresh waters across cold-climate regions [3, 4]. It is often applied in amounts beyond what de-icing requires [5]. Beyond corroding vehicles and infrastructure [6], road salt contaminates groundwater and degrades stream water quality [2, 7], with ecological effects that include longer-term shifts in ecosystem function [8]. These effects occur at chloride concentrations at or below existing regulatory guidelines: Hintz et al. [9] found that chloride at or beneath current water-quality thresholds caused substantial losses of zooplankton in lakes across North America and Europe. Identifying *where* salt enters streams, and therefore where mitigation would be most effective, thus carries direct management value.

Although road salt is applied only in the cold months, its effects on freshwater salinity extend across the entire year [10]. Chloride concentrations are highest in winter [11], but stored salt keeps stream salinity elevated into the summer [12], when groundwater inputs sustain many perennial streams at baseflow. As road salt has infiltrated groundwater

over recent decades [13], summertime stream salt concentrations have continued to rise through surface-groundwater exchange, with long-term increases documented globally [3, 7]. Much of the applied chloride accumulates in groundwater and is released to streams over years to decades [14], so summer baseflow salinity integrates decades of past application rather than the most recent winter alone. This raises the question of what controls where that stored salt re-emerges.

Fault zones are one candidate control. They are commonly described as conduit–barrier systems, in which a low-permeability core is flanked by a fractured damage zone that can favor flow along the fault while hindering flow across it; whether a particular fault acts as a conduit, a barrier, or both depends on its architecture and hydrogeologic setting [15, 16]. In fractured metamorphic bedrock of New England, foliation-parallel fractures can raise connectivity and add flow anisotropy [17], and in the northeastern Appalachian foreland the Hinesburg thrust fault in Vermont influences well yield and water chemistry [18]. Neither study concerns road salt. A dye-tracer study of a fault zone in Cretaceous limestone in Texas measured groundwater moving rapidly parallel to the fault [19]; we cite it only as a carbonate example of how anisotropic fault-parallel flow can be, because karst is not a direct analogue for the metasedimentary bedrock of our study area. The closest evidence linking faults to road salt comes from bedrock wells: Schalk and Stasulis [20] documented four road-salt-contaminated wells along a fault zone in Maine, with elevated specific conductance in both summer and winter, traced to a roadway running along the fault's trace. Direct evidence that faults deliver highway road salt to streams remains scarce, leaving open whether they act as conduits that route contaminated groundwater to surface water. Resolving this matters because it would identify streams at risk through a fault even where no road runs nearby.

Salinization is increasingly viewed as a coupled process, the "freshwater salinization syndrome" [21] or "anthropogenic salt cycle" [22], in which geology and hydrologic flowpaths are first-order controls on where salt reaches streams [23]. This motivates a search for the specific structures that concentrate delivery of stored salt to surface water.

Tributary confluences are a more familiar cause of abrupt longitudinal changes in stream conductance. Where a tributary joins the main stem, the conductance downstream of the junction is approximately the discharge-weighted average of the two inflowing waters, a two-end-member mixing relation of the kind used to separate flow components from tracer concentrations [24]. A tributary with lower conductance than the main stem therefore dilutes it, and one with higher conductance raises it, by an amount set by the ratio of discharges and the contrast in conductance. A step in conductance at a confluence is thus expected without any fault. A step at a fault crossing with no tributary entering requires a different explanation, such as solute added from groundwater along the reach. Dilution by a tributary could also partly mask a groundwater input at the same location, which we cannot separate without discharge measurements. We therefore treat tributary and fault boundaries as distinct kinds of contrast.

We therefore ask whether sharp increases in stream salinity coincide spatially with mapped high-angle faults in a way consistent with fault-conduit transport of road-salt-contaminated groundwater from highway to stream. If faults do route such groundwater to streams, three predictions follow. First, where a conductive fault crosses a channel, salt-laden groundwater discharging along the structure should produce an abrupt, localized rise in specific conductance between the reaches immediately upstream and downstream of the crossing, rather than the gradual downstream drift expected from diffuse inputs; dense longitudinal surveys have been used to locate point groundwater inputs of road salt to streams in this way [25–27]. Second, the step should persist during baseflow in summer and early autumn, when direct runoff is absent and groundwater supplies much of the streamflow at low flow [28]. Third, it should be reflected in chloride, and in chloride-to-bromide ratios, which are the standard fingerprint of deicing salt [29].

We test these predictions with a case study of Wappinger Creek in Dutchess County, New York, combining dense longitudinal surveys of specific conductance, mapped fault traces, and a single chloride transect. We focused on reaches where mapped high-angle faults cross the channel. The study is a hypothesis-generating screening case study: it can show whether the predicted pattern is visible in a low-cost survey, and what a conclusive test would require, but it cannot by itself demonstrate that faults transport road salt.

# 2 Methods

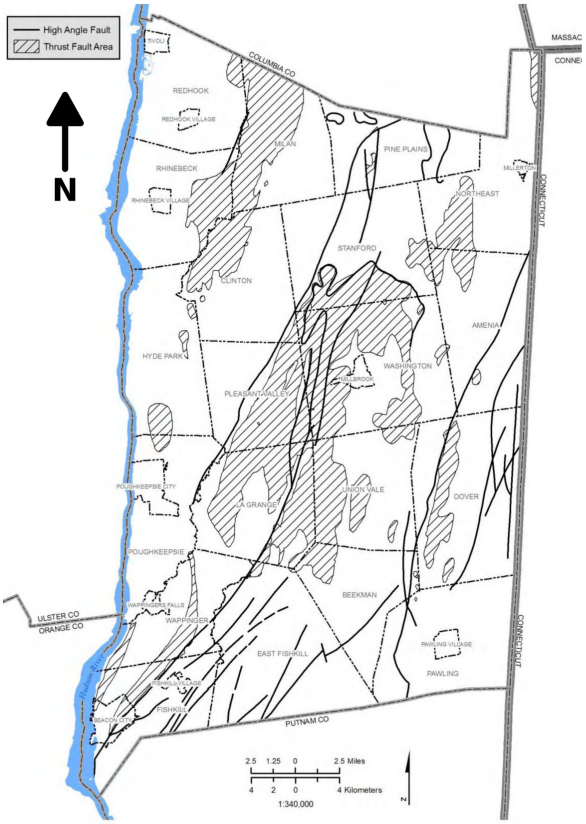
## 2.1 Site description

For our study we selected three segments of Wappinger Creek, a tributary to the Hudson River in Dutchess County, New York, USA. Each site was chosen based on two factors: whether one or more high-angle faults intersect the stream, and whether the segment could be accessed safely for field measurements. A geologic fault-line map of Dutchess County [30] allowed us to locate each stream intersection with a high-angle fault and to create a map (Figure 1) containing both fault lines and major roads. Wappinger Creek intersects State Highways 44, 55, and 9, as well as

the Taconic State Parkway, in various sections. Multiple faults bisect the creek in its upper east fork and its middle section, and the traces of some of these structures appear to control the channel's course, most visibly at Sites 1 and 2. Budnik et al. [30] describe the fault locations as "largely conjectural since the faults themselves are rarely exposed at the surface" (p. 18), so the mapped traces are approximate and we draw them as lines without an error zone.

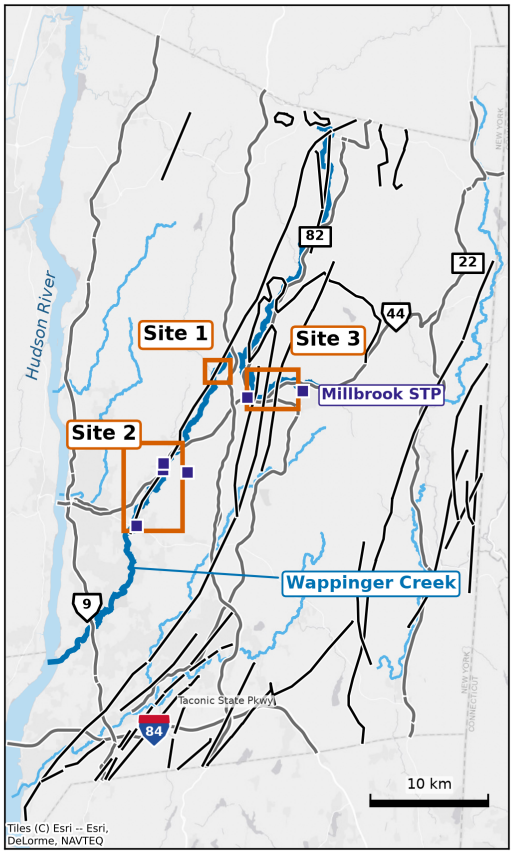
The bedrock beneath the study area consists of metamorphosed clastic sedimentary rocks that were folded and faulted during the Taconic Orogeny, and it is cut by low-angle thrust faults as well as steeper, high-angle faults [30]. This structural setting is central to our hypothesis, because fault zones typically comprise a fractured, high-permeability damage zone flanking a lower-permeability core, and can therefore behave as preferential conduits, as barriers, or as combined conduit–barrier systems for groundwater flow [15, 16]. If the high-angle faults crossing Wappinger Creek are conduits, they could in principle route road-salt-laden groundwater from a highway to the channel even where the two are separated by a topographic divide, which motivated our focus on stream reaches that coincide with mapped fault traces. Whether they do so is the question we test.

(a) Budnik et al. (2010) fault map




Taken directly from Budnik, Walker & Menking (2010), Fig. 3.10, Natural Resource Inventory of Dutchess County, NY.

(b) Study area: faults, highways and streams




High-angle fault (Budnik et al. 2010)
Wappinger Creek
Other major streams
Major highway
Study site
Wastewater facility
Interstate
US route
NY State route

Figure 1: Study area overview. (a) The county fault map, taken directly from Budnik et al. [30], Fig. 3.10, showing high-angle faults and thrust-fault areas across Dutchess County. (b) The three study reaches (orange boxes) on the Esri World Gray Canvas basemap, with the high-angle faults digitized from the same map (black lines), Wappinger Creek (dark blue) and other major streams (light blue) and the Hudson River area from USGS NHD, and major highways from TIGER 2024 (US Census Bureau). Squares: wastewater facilities holding discharge permits, plotted at their EPA ECHO facility locations (retrieved 2026-11-08); outfall locations are not mapped. The fault locations are from a county-scale map that states no positional accuracy and describes them as largely conjectural (p. 18), so they are drawn as lines. Reach-scale conductivity for each site is detailed in Figures 2–4.

## 2.2 In-situ sampling

Conductivity measurements were made on four days in autumn 2018: Site 1 on 28 September, Site 2 on 5 October, and Site 3 on 19 and 26 October. The two Site 3 days correspond to three field surveys: one on 19 October (field site 3), and two on 26 October (field sites 4 and 5), which together repeat part of the 19 October reach. We measured from upstream to downstream, approximately every 100 m at Sites 1 and 3 and about every 400 m along the longer Site 2 reach, traversing either on foot inside or around the creek or floating along the channel. Sampling was performed in the thalweg of each study site, which reduced variation due to incomplete lateral mixing. We used a Thermo Scientific Orion 013010MD conductivity cell, calibrated following the standard protocols outlined by the manufacturer, with readings temperature-compensated to 25 °C and reported as specific conductance. The meters used with this cell specify an accuracy of $\pm 0.5\%$ of reading $\pm 1$ digit, about $\pm 1.7$ $\mu$S/cm at 310 $\mu$S/cm. A calibration offset shared by all readings on one day cancels when zones are compared within that day; random reading error does not. We inferred changes in the salt input to the stream along its length from changes in specific conductance.

Mean spacing between points was about 85 m at Site 1, 416 m at Site 2 and 83–118 m on the Site 3 surveys, yielding 9, 18, and 46 measurement points at Sites 1, 2, and 3, respectively, with point positions recorded using a handheld GPS unit. Along-channel distance for each survey was computed by summing great-circle distances between consecutive GPS fixes in survey order, with the surveys that were walked upstream reversed so that distance increases downstream. Within each site we delineated zones bounded at the locations where the creek crosses a mapped fault trace (at Site 2, the fault position interpreted in the field) or receives an active tributary, so that the reaches immediately upstream and downstream of a single geologic or hydrologic feature could be compared directly. To isolate the effect of faults, we restricted our fault-crossing contrasts to reaches where the creek intersects a mapped fault without a coincident tributary, because a tributary confluence introduces an independent salinity signal that would confound the comparison. Because the fault traces are mapped at county scale and are largely conjectural [30], we treated each crossing as a reach-scale rather than a point-scale feature when assigning zone boundaries. Some survey points were flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the mapped fault; the flag records what we believed at the time of sampling, not an observed fault position. Zones are numbered such that they ascend as the river goes downstream: for example zone 3-3 is downstream of 3-2 which is downstream of 3-1. At Site 2 the digitized county-scale trace runs along the creek for the whole surveyed reach, so it cannot resolve where the fault crosses the channel. We placed the boundary between Zones 2-1 and 2-2 (Contrast B), about 4 km along the survey, at the position where we interpret the fault to be in the field: an abrupt, roughly 90° turn of the channel, which we took to be the creek turning to follow the fault and therefore a likely place of preferential groundwater flow along the structure. The boundary is thus a field interpretation of channel geometry, not a position taken from the mapped trace, whose locations are largely conjectural [30]. An abrupt bend is consistent with structural control of the channel, but it does not by itself show that groundwater flows along the fault there.

Chloride concentration was measured on 20 July 2020 within Site 3, upstream and downstream of the long-term monitoring location of Kelly et al. [31], to determine whether rises in chloride concentration occurred close to the mapped geologic faults. The transect extended about 2.35 km along the east fork, from an upstream point Z (0 m) to a downstream point Z' (2,351 m; Figure 5), with the monitoring location of Kelly et al. [31] at about 1,224 m. It comprises 18 main-stem samples and one sample from a side tributary. Chloride was measured in the stream with a YSI Pro Series 1005 chloride ion-selective electrode (YSI 605105) on a YSI handheld meter, a sensor the manufacturer specifies for freshwater use only. The manufacturer gives a range of 0–1,000 mg/L, a resolution of 0.01 mg/L, and an accuracy of $\pm 15\%$ of reading or $\pm 5$ mg/L, whichever is greater, and recommends a two-point calibration with standards two orders of magnitude apart (10 and 1,000 mg/L). At the concentrations we measured (about 14–50 mg/L) the stated accuracy is therefore $\pm 5$ to $\pm 7.5$ mg/L, so differences of a few mg/L between neighboring samples are within the instrument's uncertainty. It was collected in summer at baseflow, when elevated chloride is more plausibly attributed to groundwater than to concurrent runoff. It is a single transect from a different year than the conductivity survey, so it cannot confirm the conductivity pattern; we analyzed it descriptively and with the change-point method below.

## 2.3 Statistical analysis

We separated the specific-conductance samples into zones defined by where geologic interactions occur, that is, where the stream crosses either a fault or a side-stream. We then applied a two-sample Welch $t$-test (Equation 1) to evaluate the difference in mean specific conductance, in $\mu$S/cm, upstream and downstream of each feature. Unlike Student's pooled $t$-test, Welch's version does not assume equal variances and remains reliable with unequal sample sizes, as ours are, and is recommended as the default two-sample test [32].

$$t = \frac{\overline{x}_2 - \overline{x}_1}{\sqrt{\dfrac{s_1^2}{n_1} + \dfrac{s_2^2}{n_2}}} \tag{1}$$

Here $\overline{x}_1$ and $\overline{x}_2$ are the mean specific conductance of the upstream and downstream zones, $s_1$ and $s_2$ their standard deviations, and $n_1$ and $n_2$ their sample sizes. Zones are compared only within a single survey day. Synoptic comparisons along a stream assume steady conditions, because concentrations that change between sampling runs are a source of uncertainty in a longitudinal profile [33]. At Site 3 the two survey days differ by a consistent offset: eleven pairs of 19 and 26 October points lying within 120 m of one another differ by 23.5 to 29.7 $\mu$S/cm (mean 27.8 $\mu$S/cm), larger than any of the contrasts we test. We did not pool days, add a day covariate, or correct for the offset. Contrast D is therefore tested on 19 October, and Contrast E on 26 October. We evaluated significance with two-tailed tests at $\alpha = 0.05$. Because our zone samples are relatively small and not guaranteed to be normally distributed, we accompanied every Welch test with a distribution-free Mann–Whitney $U$ test and regard a contrast as robust only where the two approaches agree, which guards against over-interpreting the smaller contrasts.

Applying a $t$-test to measurements collected sequentially along a channel warrants caution, because closely spaced samples are not strictly independent and nominal $p$-values are therefore likely too small. For each contrast we estimated the lag-1 autocorrelation $\rho$ of the residuals from the two zone means, pooled in along-channel order. Negative values were set to zero and $\rho$ was capped at 0.9. We then computed an effective sample size for each zone, $n_{\mathrm{eff}} = n(1-\rho)/(1+\rho)$, floored at 2 and not exceeding $n$, and repeated the Welch test with $n_{\mathrm{eff}}$ in place of $n$ (degrees of freedom by the Welch–Satterthwaite approximation). With zones of three to eleven points, $\rho$ is poorly determined, so we treat the adjusted $p$-values as a sensitivity check rather than a correction.

Zone means cannot show whether a change in conductance is abrupt or gradual, so we also looked for change points along each transect. For each single-day transect separately (Site 1, Site 2, the 19 October survey at Site 3, and the upper and lower 26 October surveys at Site 3), we fitted continuous piecewise-linear regressions of specific conductance on along-channel distance with zero, one, or two breakpoints, requiring at least three points in each segment, and chose the number of breakpoints by the Bayesian information criterion (BIC). Uncertainty in each breakpoint was assessed with a residual bootstrap (500 replicates). As an independent check we applied a penalized change-in-mean analysis (PELT, `ruptures` package). The same procedure was applied to the chloride transect.

Finally, because roads are a possible alternative source of the conductance differences, we computed the distance from each survey point to the nearest major road, defined as primary or secondary roads (TIGER/Line 2024 feature classes S1100 and S1200). We report these distances descriptively by zone and do not test them.

# 3 Results

## 3.1 Within-day zone contrasts

Zones are compared only within a single survey day, so the results are reported survey by survey. Table 1 gives each contrast with zone means $\pm$ SD and the number of points $n$; Table 2 gives the autocorrelation-adjusted $p$-values and the median distance from each zone's points to the nearest major road; Appendix A lists every measurement. Within a single day the zone standard deviations are 0.1–2.6 $\mu$S/cm.

**Site 1, Contrast A (28 September).** Specific conductance fell from 259.9 $\pm$ 0.7 $\mu$S/cm in Zone 1-1 ($n = 4$) to 259.4 $\pm$ 0.1 $\mu$S/cm in Zone 1-2 ($n = 5$), a change of $-0.5$ $\mu$S/cm that is not significant (Figure 2; Table 1). A tributary enters at the same place where the channel turns along the mapped fault trace, and the field log records very high flow after rain throughout the Site 1 survey; conductance there was 50–100 $\mu$S/cm lower than at the other sites, consistent with dilution by runoff, so this contrast cannot isolate a fault effect and, with four and five points, has little power.

**Site 2, Contrast B (5 October).** Zone 2-1 averaged 308.8 $\pm$ 1.1 $\mu$S/cm ($n = 10$) and Zone 2-2 averaged 313.1 $\pm$ 1.9 $\mu$S/cm ($n = 8$), an increase of $+4.3$ $\mu$S/cm (95% CI $+2.6$ to $+6.0$; Welch $p < 0.001$; Mann–Whitney $p < 0.001$; Figure 3). Allowing for autocorrelation along the channel ($n_{\mathrm{eff}} = 4.6$ and 3.7), the adjusted $p$ is 0.017 (Table 2). The difference is larger than the within-zone standard deviations and about 2.5 times the instrument's stated accuracy at this conductance ($\pm 1.7$ $\mu$S/cm at 310 $\mu$S/cm). The Zone 2-1/2-2 boundary, about 4.0 km along the survey, is the fault position we interpreted in the field from the abrupt 90° channel bend (Section 2.2). The digitized county-scale trace runs along the creek throughout and crosses the survey line at about 1.0 and 5.8 km, but those intersections are not reliable fault positions, so we did not use them. The field log records very high flow at the start of the Site 2 survey, part of which was made by canoe, so this survey may not represent baseflow.

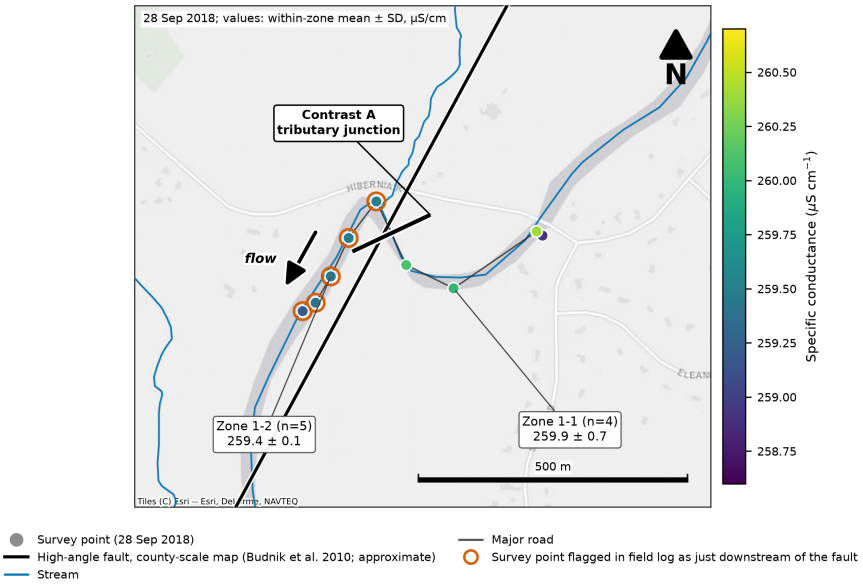



Figure 2: Site 1, surveyed on 28 September 2018 (Contrast A). Circles are survey points coloured by specific conductance; the colour scale spans only 258.9–260.4 $\mu$S/cm, comparable to the instrument's stated accuracy (about $\pm 1.4$ $\mu$S/cm at 260 $\mu$S/cm). Orange rings mark survey points flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the fault. The black line is the high-angle fault digitized from Budnik et al. [30], drawn without an error zone because the source map states no positional accuracy. Zone labels give the number of points and the within-day mean $\pm$ SD (in $\mu$S/cm); Zones 1-1 and 1-2 are numbered downstream, and the arrow shows flow direction. Streams are from USGS NHD, major roads from TIGER 2024 (US Census Bureau), and the basemap is Esri World Gray Canvas.

**Site 3, Contrasts C, D and E (19 and 26 October).** Contrast C, the tributary junction, is a decrease on both days: $-3.8$ $\mu$S/cm on 19 October ($340.1 \pm 0.4$, $n = 6$, to $336.3 \pm 2.2$, $n = 3$; Welch $p = 0.093$; Mann–Whitney $p = 0.028$) and $-5.6$ $\mu$S/cm on 26 October ($370.5 \pm 2.6$, $n = 11$, to $364.9 \pm 1.1$, $n = 3$; $p < 0.001$, adjusted $p = 0.041$). On 19 October the two tests disagree, so by the criterion in Section 2.3 this contrast does not meet our robustness criterion; the Mann–Whitney $p$ is an asymptotic value computed with ties and groups of only 6 and 3 points, for which the smallest attainable exact $p$ is about 0.024. The downstream zone has only three points, so these tests have little power. Contrast D, the first fault, can be tested only on 19 October, because on 26 October Zones 3-2 and 3-3 lie on different transects 1.1 km apart. It is a decrease of $-2.8$ $\mu$S/cm ($336.3 \pm 2.2$, $n = 3$, to $333.4 \pm 1.9$, $n = 11$; 95% CI $-7.4$ to $+1.7$; $p = 0.140$). Contrast E, the second fault, can be tested only on 26 October. Conductance rose from $358.8 \pm 1.8$ $\mu$S/cm ($n = 6$) in Zone 3-3 to $360.4 \pm 0.8$ $\mu$S/cm ($n = 6$) in Zone 3-4, an increase of $+1.6$ $\mu$S/cm (95% CI $-0.3$ to $+3.4$; Welch $p = 0.090$; Mann–Whitney $p = 0.076$; adjusted $p = 0.243$), which is not significant and within the instrument's stated accuracy ($\pm 1.9$ $\mu$S/cm at 360 $\mu$S/cm). The tributary contrast (C) thus behaves as mixing predicts, a decrease where lower-conductance water enters, while neither Site 3 fault contrast shows a significant increase.

**Pooling days.** When the two survey days are pooled, Contrast E appears as a rise of $+18.0$ $\mu$S/cm ($p < 0.001$), larger than any other step in the survey. That value is an artefact of pooling two survey days. Zone 3-3 would then combine 11 points from 19 October (333.4 $\mu$S/cm) with 6 from 26 October (358.8 $\mu$S/cm), giving a pooled mean of 342.4 $\mu$S/cm, whereas Zone 3-4 consists only of 26 October points. The "step" is the difference between days, not a change along the channel; the same pooling inflates the zone standard deviations to 12.6–15.8 $\mu$S/cm, against 0.4–2.6 $\mu$S/cm within a day.

**Day offset and the repeated reach.** Eleven 19 October points have a 26 October point within 120 m, and the pairs differ by 23.5–29.7 $\mu$S/cm (mean 27.8, SD 2.2); two points 18 m apart at the seam between the surveys read 332.0 and 355.5 $\mu$S/cm. The offset is therefore not constant, and its range of about 6 $\mu$S/cm exceeds Contrasts B and E, which is why we neither pooled days nor corrected for it. Zones 3-1 and 3-2 were surveyed on both days (Figure 4, inset): Zone 3-1 averaged $340.1 \pm 0.4$ $\mu$S/cm ($n = 6$) on 19 October and $370.5 \pm 2.6$ ($n = 11$) on 26 October, and Zone 3-2 averaged $336.3 \pm 2.2$ ($n = 3$) and $364.9 \pm 1.1$ ($n = 3$), so within each day the zones are internally consistent but the two days differ by about 29–30 $\mu$S/cm.

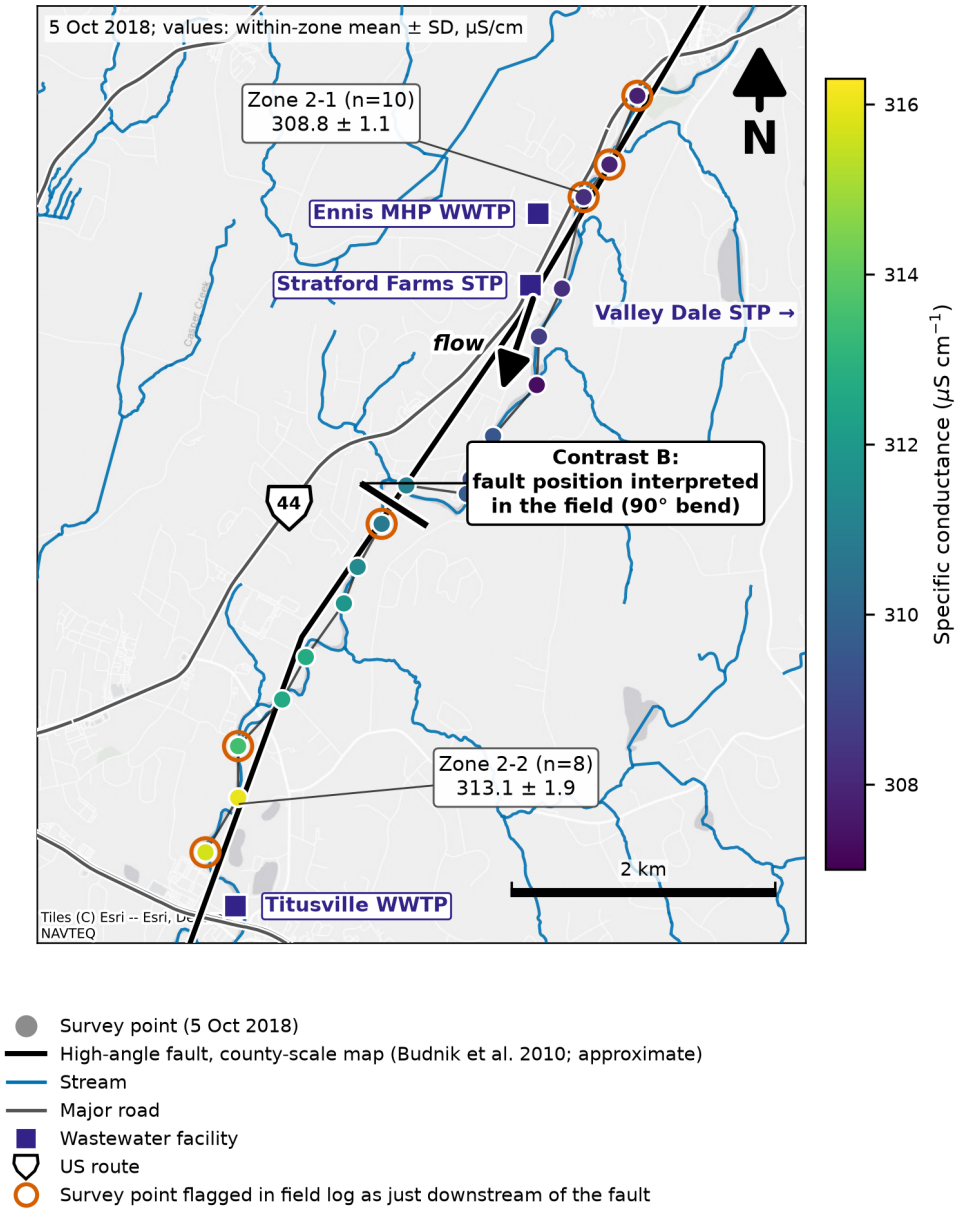



Figure 3: Site 2, surveyed on 5 October 2018 (Contrast B). Symbols as in Figure 2; the colour scale spans 307–316 $\mu$S/cm and zone labels give the number of points and within-day mean $\pm$ SD. The Contrast B boundary between Zones 2-1 and 2-2, at about 4.0 km along the survey, is the fault position interpreted in the field from an abrupt 90° bend in the channel. The digitized fault line runs along the creek for the whole reach and, being from a county-scale map, cannot resolve where the fault crosses the channel. Squares: wastewater facilities holding discharge permits, plotted at their EPA ECHO facility locations (retrieved 2026-11-08); outfall locations are not mapped. Streams are from USGS NHD, major roads from TIGER 2024 (US Census Bureau), faults are digitized from Budnik et al. [30], and the basemap is Esri World Gray Canvas.

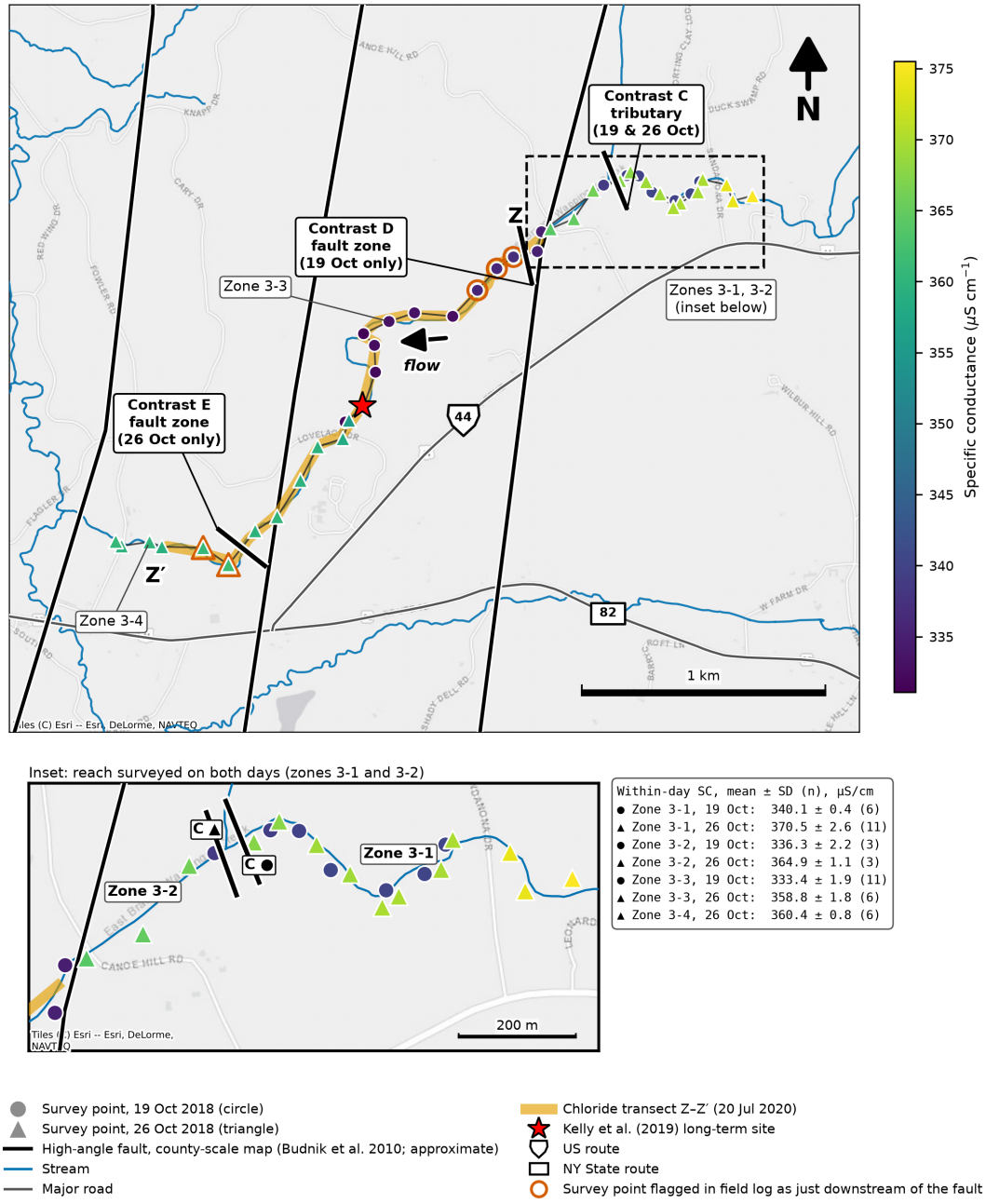



Figure 4: Site 3 (Contrasts C, D and E). Circles are survey points from 19 October 2018 and triangles from 26 October 2018, coloured by specific conductance on a shared scale; because the two days differ by about 28 $\mu$S/cm (23.5–29.7 $\mu$S/cm for nearby point pairs), the colours mainly separate the days, and zones are compared within a day only (Contrast D on 19 October, Contrast E on 26 October, Contrast C on both). Orange rings mark survey points flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the fault. The inset enlarges the reach surveyed on both days (Zones 3-1 and 3-2), and the panel beside it lists the within-day mean $\pm$ SD and number of points for each zone and day. The yellow band is the 20 July 2020 chloride transect from Z to Z′, and the red star is the long-term monitoring site of Kelly et al. [31]. The arrow shows flow direction. Faults are digitized from Budnik et al. [30] and drawn as lines without an error zone; streams are from USGS NHD, major roads from TIGER 2024 (US Census Bureau), and the basemap is Esri World Gray Canvas.

### 3.2 Chloride transect

The 20 July 2020 transect (Figure 5) ran 2,351 m from Z to Z′, starting near the survey points flagged for Contrast D and ending just downstream of those flagged for Contrast E, so it lies mostly within Zone 3-3. Chloride across the 18 main-stem samples ranged from 13.75 to 50.0 mg/L, with the highest values at 474 m (50.0 mg/L), 690 m (36.25 mg/L) and 959 m (40.0 mg/L). These lie 133–468 m from the nearest flagged point for Contrast D and 293–391 m from the nearest digitized fault trace. The segmented regression selects one breakpoint at 467 m (bootstrap interval 308–800 m), where the fitted slope changes from $+53$ to $-15$ mg/L per km; the change-in-mean analysis places shifts at 384 and 1021 m. The breakpoint is about 125 m from the nearest Contrast D flagged point and about 300 m from the nearest trace, but it is driven largely by the single 50 mg/L sample. Near Contrast E, chloride is low and flat: only 2 of the 18 samples lie downstream of the Contrast E flagged points (13.75 and 15.0 mg/L), and the last five samples are 13.75–17.5 mg/L. The transect therefore shows no chloride increase at Contrast E. With so few points downstream of E we did not attempt a two-sample test.

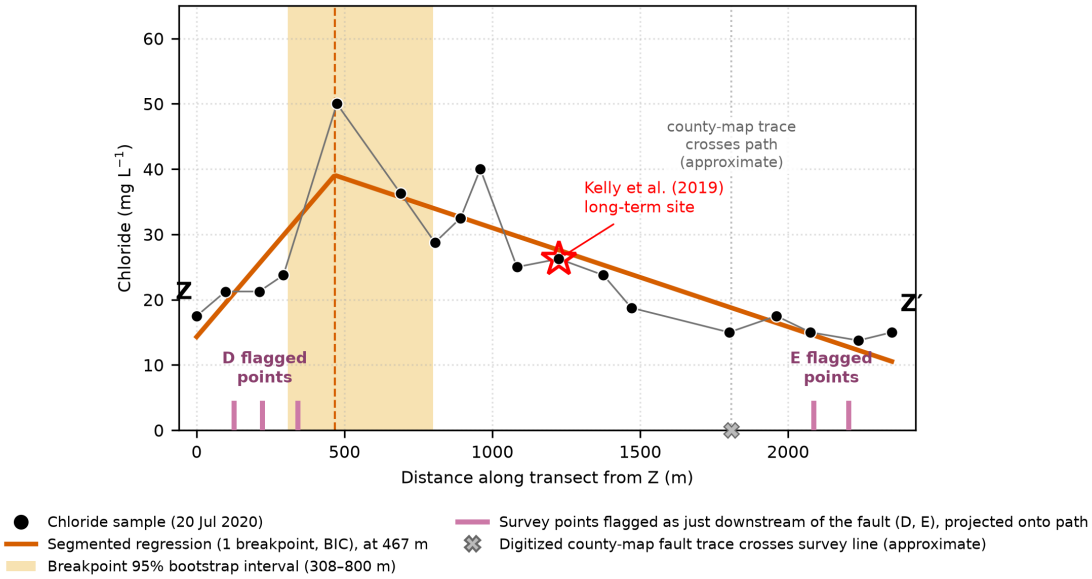



Figure 5: Chloride along the 20 July 2020 transect from Z to Z′ (distance from Z). Black points are the 18 main-stem samples (the side-tributary sample is excluded). The orange line is the one-breakpoint segmented regression selected by BIC (breakpoint at 467 m; tan band, 95% bootstrap interval 308–800 m). Pink ticks mark the survey points flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the fault for Contrasts D (126, 222, 342 m) and E (2087, 2205 m), projected onto the transect; the blue cross marks where the digitized county-map fault trace crosses the survey line (approximate; 1809 m; faults digitized from Budnik et al. [30]). The red star is the long-term monitoring site of Kelly et al. [31]. The transect lies mostly within Zone 3-3, starting near the Contrast D flagged points and ending just downstream of the Contrast E flagged points. The breakpoint depends largely on the single 50 mg/L sample at 474 m.

### 3.3 Change-point analysis of specific conductance

Segmented regression and a change-in-mean check on each single-day transect (Figure 6) find no specific-conductance breakpoint at a fault contrast boundary or at a point where the digitized trace crosses the transect. At Site 2 one breakpoint is selected at 2,355 m (bootstrap interval 1,327–3,384 m), after which conductance rises steadily downstream; the fitted slope increases from 0.1 to 1.6 $\mu$S/cm per km. This breakpoint lies about 1.6 km upstream of the Contrast B boundary, the field-interpreted fault position at the channel bend (3,993 m; 0.6–2.7 km given the bootstrap interval); the change-in-mean analysis places three small shifts ($+1.5$, $+2.3$ and $+3.3$ $\mu$S/cm) between 2.6 and 5.9 km. Contrast B is therefore better described as part of a gradual downstream ramp than as an abrupt step at the interpreted fault position. At Site 1 and on the 19 October Site 3 transect no breakpoint is selected (for 19 October a one-breakpoint model ties with none, $\Delta$BIC = 0.03). On the upper 26 October Site 3 transect two breakpoints (300 and 459 m) are only marginally preferred ($\Delta$BIC = 0.3) and lie 314–473 m from the tributary and away from any trace. On the lower 26 October transect (Contrast E) one breakpoint is selected at 194 m, where conductance rises from 355.5 to 359.7 $\mu$S/cm over the first 190 m and then stays near 360 $\mu$S/cm. This breakpoint sits at the minimum segment length the method

allows, 330 m upstream of where the channel crosses the digitized trace (at 523 m), 123 m in straight-line distance from the nearest trace, and 522 m upstream of the Contrast E boundary.

Table 1: Within-day zone contrasts (Welch $t$-test on specific conductance in $\mu$S/cm). Contr.: contrast; Boundary: whether the boundary between the two zones is a mapped fault or a tributary junction; Date: the single survey day used; Zones: upstream $\rightarrow$ downstream; $n_1, n_2$: number of points in the upstream and downstream zone ($^\dagger$ marks a contrast with a zone of $n < 5$); Up and Down: zone mean $\pm$ SD; $\Delta$ [95% CI]: difference in means, downstream $-$ upstream, with the Welch 95% confidence interval; Welch $t$ (df): test statistic with Welch–Satterthwaite degrees of freedom; $p$: two-tailed Welch $p$-value; $U$ and $p_{\mathrm{MW}}$: Mann–Whitney statistic (downstream sample) and $p$-value. $\Delta$ = downstream $-$ upstream; within-day comparisons only. Contrast D cannot be tested on 26 October and Contrast E cannot be tested on 19 October (see text). With a zone of three or four points these tests have very little power.

| Contr. | Boundary | Date | Zones | $n_1, n_2$ | Up (mean±SD) | Down (mean±SD) | $\Delta$ [95% CI] | Welch $t$ (df) | $p$ | $U$ | $p_{\mathrm{MW}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | tributary | 28 Sep | 1-1→1-2 | 4,5$^\dagger$ | 259.9±0.7 | 259.4±0.1 | -0.5 [-1.5, +0.6] | -1.35 (3.2) | 0.264 | 5 | 0.266 |
| B | fault | 5 Oct | 2-1→2-2 | 10,8 | 308.8±1.1 | 313.1±1.9 | +4.3 [+2.6, +6.0] | 5.63 (10.8) | <0.001 | 79 | <0.001 |
| C | tributary | 19 Oct | 3-1→3-2 | 6,3$^\dagger$ | 340.1±0.4 | 336.3±2.2 | -3.8 [-9.2, +1.5] | -2.97 (2.1) | 0.093 | 0 | 0.028 |
| C | tributary | 26 Oct | 3-1→3-2 | 11,3$^\dagger$ | 370.5±2.6 | 364.9±1.1 | -5.6 [-7.9, -3.3] | -5.48 (8.8) | <0.001 | 0 | 0.012 |
| D | fault | 19 Oct | 3-2→3-3 | 3,11$^\dagger$ | 336.3±2.2 | 333.4±1.9 | -2.8 [-7.4, +1.7] | -2.02 (2.9) | 0.140 | 6 | 0.119 |
| E | fault | 26 Oct | 3-3→3-4 | 6,6 | 358.8±1.8 | 360.4±0.8 | +1.6 [-0.3, +3.4] | 1.96 (7.0) | 0.090 | 30 | 0.076 |

Table 2: Support for Table 1. $\hat{\rho}_1$: lag-1 autocorrelation of residuals from the two zone means, pooled in along-channel order (negative values set to zero); $n_{\mathrm{eff},1}$, $n_{\mathrm{eff},2}$: effective sample sizes of the upstream and downstream zone, $n_{\mathrm{eff}} = n(1-\rho)/(1+\rho)$; $p$ (Welch): nominal $p$-value; $p$ ($n_{\mathrm{eff}}$): Welch $p$-value recomputed with $n_{\mathrm{eff}}$; last two columns: median distance (m) from the zone's survey points to the nearest major road (TIGER/Line 2024 primary and secondary roads; the Taconic State Parkway is coded as a local road and is not counted). $\hat{\rho}_1$ is poorly determined from three to eleven points, so the adjusted $p$-values are a sensitivity check; road distances are descriptive only and were not tested.

| Contr. | Date | Zones | $\hat{\rho}_1$ | $n_{\mathrm{eff},1}$ | $n_{\mathrm{eff},2}$ | $p$ (Welch) | $p$ ($n_{\mathrm{eff}}$) | Median road dist. (m) | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | | | up | down |
| A | 28 Sep | 1-1→1-2 | -0.27 | 4.0 | 5.0 | 0.264 | 0.264 | 927 | 751 |
| B | 5 Oct | 2-1→2-2 | 0.37 | 4.6 | 3.7 | <0.001 | 0.017 | 335 | 726 |
| C | 19 Oct | 3-1→3-2 | -0.35 | 6.0 | 3.0 | 0.093 | 0.093 | 304 | 425 |
| C | 26 Oct | 3-1→3-2 | 0.54 | 3.2 | 2.0 | <0.001 | 0.041 | 245 | 414 |
| D | 19 Oct | 3-2→3-3 | 0.35 | 2.0 | 5.3 | 0.140 | 0.279 | 425 | 409 |
| E | 26 Oct | 3-3→3-4 | 0.30 | 3.2 | 3.2 | 0.090 | 0.243 | 312 | 368 |

# 4 Discussion

## 4.1 What the survey shows

The question posed by the title is whether fault zones route road-salt-contaminated groundwater to streams. The survey does not answer it clearly. Of the three contrasts at mapped faults, one shows a small, significant increase in specific conductance (Contrast B, $+4.3$ $\mu$S/cm), one shows a non-significant decrease (Contrast D, $-2.8$ $\mu$S/cm) and one shows a non-significant increase within instrument accuracy (Contrast E, $+1.6$ $\mu$S/cm). No conductance breakpoint on any transect coincides with a fault contrast boundary.

Contrast B is an observation worth testing, not evidence of fault transport. It is a gradual rise that begins roughly 1.6 km upstream of the zone boundary, which marks the fault position we interpreted in the field at an abrupt channel bend, along a reach where the county-scale fault trace runs parallel to the creek and cannot show where the fault meets the channel. A rise of this kind is what diffuse groundwater input, or a fault-parallel flowpath delivering water along the reach, would both produce, and the survey cannot tell them apart. Contrast D, at a fault with no tributary, shows no increase. Contrast E is within the instrument's stated accuracy and its only breakpoint lies near the start of a short transect, 330 m upstream of where the channel crosses the trace. The 2020 chloride transect adds a further observation worth testing: its peak lies near the Contrast D flagged points and about 300 m from the nearest trace, but it rests on one sample, comes from a different year, and chloride near Contrast E is low (about 14–15 mg/L). We do not treat the chloride peak as support for the conductance result at any contrast.

The tributary contrast is an internal check. Contrast C decreases conductance on both days, as two-end-member mixing predicts when lower-conductance water joins the main stem [24], so the survey can detect a known input of the size

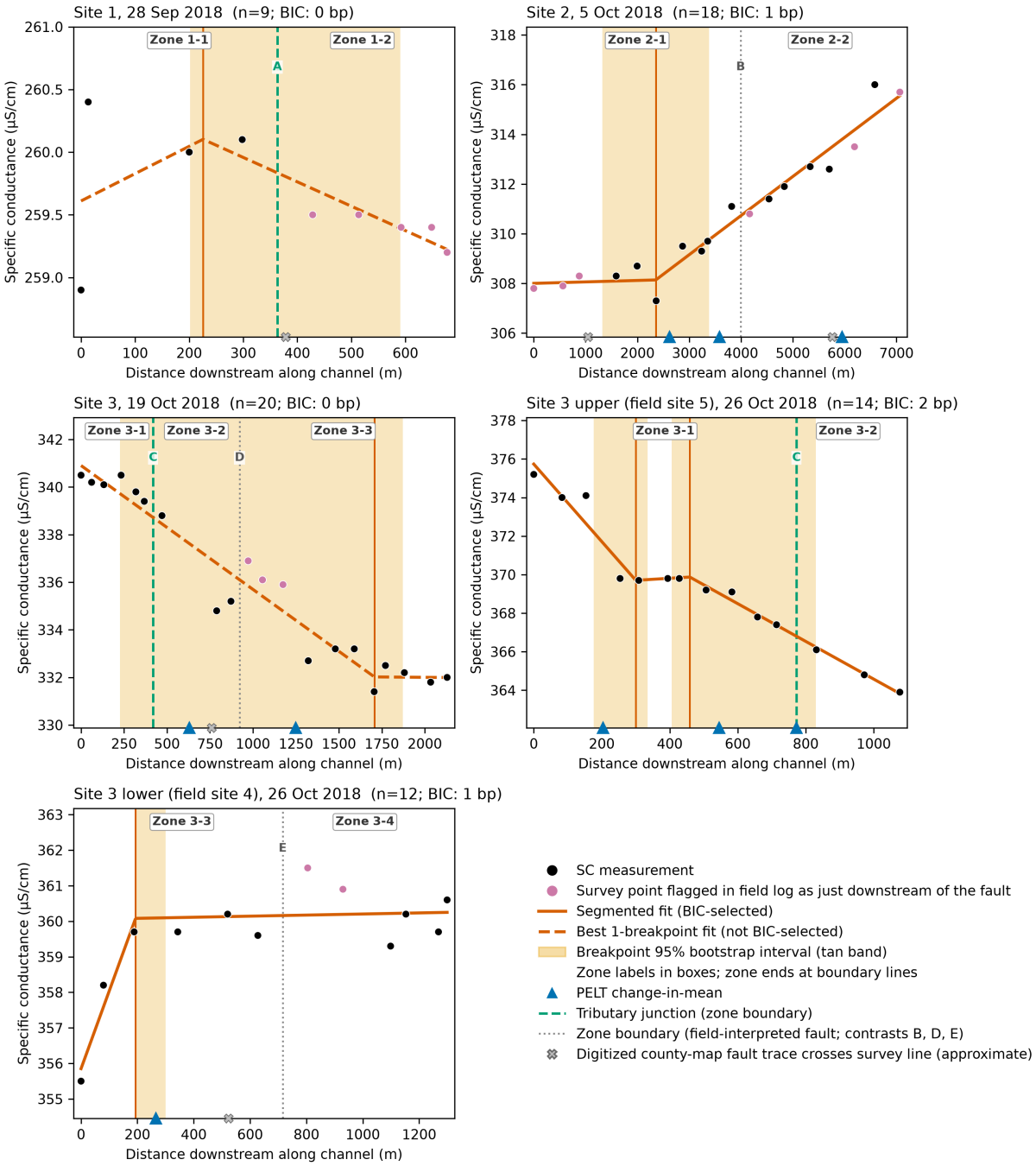



Figure 6: Specific conductance against along-channel distance for each single-day transect: Site 1 (28 September 2018), Site 2 (5 October), Site 3 on 19 October, and the upper (field site 5) and lower (field site 4) Site 3 transects on 26 October. Black points are measurements; pink points are survey points flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the mapped fault. The solid orange line is the segmented fit selected by BIC and the dashed line the best one-breakpoint fit where none is selected; tan bands are 95% bootstrap intervals for breakpoints. Blue triangles mark change-in-mean (PELT) shifts and blue crosses mark where the digitized county-map fault trace crosses the survey line (approximate; faults from Budnik et al. [30]). Green dashed lines mark tributary junctions and grey dotted lines the zone boundaries of fault contrasts (for Contrast B, the fault position interpreted in the field); zone labels are in boxes. Vertical axes differ between panels and each panel shows one survey day only.

we are discussing. Dilution by a tributary could in principle also mask a groundwater input entering at the same place, which would hide a fault signal at Contrast C; we cannot test that possibility without discharge measurements.

The size of the differences also matters. The stated accuracy of the conductivity measurement is a bound on absolute error, and a calibration offset common to all readings on one day cancels in a within-day difference, but random reading error does not, and the manufacturer gives no repeatability figure. Contrast B exceeds that bound by a factor of about 2.5 and exceeds the within-zone scatter, which is why we report it as a real but small difference; Contrast E does not exceed it. Site 1, where a coincident tributary and very high flow after rain confound the only contrast, contributes little either way. Taken together, the survey is best read as a screening result: it shows what a low-cost survey can detect, namely a small gradual rise at one site and the dilution at a tributary, and it also shows that such a survey does not locate a fault-related input to within the spacing of a few hundred metres that a fault trace of uncertain position would require.

### 4.2 Alternative explanations

Several explanations for the Site 2 increase, and for the conductance differences generally, are at least as plausible as fault-routed groundwater with the data in hand.

*Road proximity.* Per-zone median distances from survey points to the nearest major road range from 245 to 927 m (Table 2). At Site 2 the downstream zone is farther from a major road than the upstream zone (median 726 versus 335 m), so proximity to a major road does not by itself explain Contrast B, although one upstream point lies only 39 m from a road and the distances do not capture drainage or road density. The Site 3 zones lie 245–425 m from the nearest major road, mainly US 44, with no monotone relation to the conductance pattern. These are descriptive medians, not a test, and they say nothing about salt stored in roadside soils and shallow groundwater, which may be flushed to the channel late in the season and which our survey cannot distinguish from deeper, fault-routed water. Our surveys were made in late September and October, so a late-season release of such stored salt is a possibility we cannot exclude; it would, like diffuse groundwater, favour a gradual rise over a step.

*Developed land.* Stream conductance also rises near developed land from sources unrelated to faults or highways, such as residential runoff and lawn and agricultural fertilizers. Site 2 runs beside US 44 and ends near the settled area around Titusville (Figure 3); we did not quantify land cover. The earlier argument that sampling within conserved land lets us discount such inputs does not hold, because the sources lie in the contributing area and not only along the survey line, and we withdraw it.

*Wastewater.* Kelly et al. [12] estimated sodium chloride sources for the East Branch of Wappinger Creek and found that road salt contributed 83% and parking-area salt 8% (91% from deicing), sewage including septic systems 4%, and water softeners 3%. Their 1% weathering term was estimated from a single 1905 chloride sample and was not measured, so it supports only the general view, also reached in a basin budget elsewhere in New England [34], that deicing salt dominates the budget. The Millbrook sewage treatment plant that they describe is upstream of all three of our sites, about 2.4 km along the channel above Site 3 and 15.3 and 25.3 km above Sites 1 and 2 (EPA ECHO facility locations). As a continuous upstream source it would raise baseline conductance but would not by itself create a step at a zone boundary. More relevant to Contrast B, two small private plants, Stratford Farms and Ennis Mobile Home Park, have listed locations 240–370 m from Zone 2-1 (Figure 3), at about 1.6 and 0.9 km along the survey, just upstream of the 2.36 km breakpoint and, for the former, within its 1.3–3.4 km bootstrap interval. These are facility locations rather than outfalls, and flows are not listed, so we cannot test whether they contribute, but they are a plausible, untested alternative source for the Site 2 increase. The Titusville plant lies just downstream of the last Site 2 survey point, so it cannot affect Contrast B, and the Valley Dale plant discharges to a tributary about 2 km away, off the frame of Figure 3.

*Diffuse groundwater.* Groundwater entering diffusely along a reach would raise conductance gradually downstream rather than in a step, and longitudinal surveys elsewhere show that local groundwater inputs and land use drive spatial variation in stream chloride [27]; the gradual ramp at Site 2 is consistent with such inputs. Long-term records show that stream chloride in this reach has risen from annual means of roughly 15 mg/L in the 1980s to over 40 mg/L by the 2010s [31], consistent with a regional anthropogenic source and a large store of salt in the subsurface [14], but a single monitoring location cannot show where along the channel that salt enters.

### 4.3 Fault hydrogeology and other longitudinal surveys

Fault zones are well described as conduit–barrier systems whose behaviour depends on the architecture of the core and damage zone and on the surrounding rock [15, 16]. In New England metamorphic bedrock, foliation-parallel fractures can raise connectivity and add flow anisotropy [17], and a thrust fault in Vermont affects well yield and water chemistry [18]. Three-dimensional models show that a fault–host contrast in hydraulic conductivity can control

where groundwater discharges [35], and age-tracer transects across faults have been used to test whether they block or channel flow [36]. These studies make fault-routed delivery plausible; none of them involves road salt, and none tests it. In the salinization-syndrome framework, geology and flowpaths are first-order controls on where salt reaches streams [23]; a fault in that view is not a separate salt source but a flowpath that could concentrate an existing anthropogenic source at points along a channel, which would matter because focused delivery could raise local concentrations toward levels that restructure plankton communities [37] and act with warming to compound those effects [38]. Our survey does not show that this happens.

The closest evidence linking faults and road salt remains the wells of Schalk and Stasulis [20], where contaminated bedrock wells lay along a fault zone beside a road that followed the fault trace. That case differs from ours in what it measures and where: it concerns groundwater in wells, with a road directly above the structure, whereas our survey measures stream water, and the major roads nearest our zones lie hundreds of metres from the channel. A carbonate example of rapid fault-parallel flow [19] shows how anisotropic such flow can be, but karst is not an analogue for metasedimentary bedrock, so it informs the question without answering it for the Wappinger Creek faults.

Other longitudinal surveys locate salt-laden groundwater inputs more directly than ours. Electromagnetic mapping of a New Hampshire streambed found discrete reaches of high-conductivity discharge [25], and streambed conductivity and temperature mapping in urban streams found porewater chloride ranging from under 100 to over 5000 mg/L within about 10 m [26]. Longitudinal chloride and radon-222 in mixed-land-use streams showed that local groundwater inputs and land use drive spatial variation [27], and long-term sampling of chloride in streams and springs has been used to trace groundwater-sourced road salt, with the highest chloride in a karst watershed in Pennsylvania occurring in summer baseflow [39]. Compared with these approaches, a thalweg survey at roughly 100–400 m spacing integrates over the whole channel flow and is less sensitive to focused inputs that vary over 10 m, so it could miss a real fault signal as well as report a spurious one.

### 4.4 Limitations

The interpretation is limited in the following ways. We have no discharge measurements, so we cannot estimate the volume of any groundwater input, convert conductance to load, or separate dilution from addition. Flow was not at baseflow everywhere: the field log records very high flow after rain throughout the Site 1 survey and at the start of the Site 2 survey, so those surveys do not meet the baseflow condition of our second prediction, and runoff may have contributed to the conductance pattern there. We have no source tracers, so we cannot attribute salt to roads, wastewater or other sources. Each reading is a single thalweg value, with no repeats across the channel or at depth, so lateral and vertical variation, which could exceed the small contrasts, is unmeasured. The instrument's stated accuracy (about $\pm 1.7$ $\mu$S/cm at 310 $\mu$S/cm and $\pm 1.9$ $\mu$S/cm at 360 $\mu$S/cm) is comparable with the step sizes: Contrast B is about 2.5 times it, Contrast E is within it, and the manufacturer gives no repeatability figure. Site 3 was surveyed on two days with a large day-to-day offset (Section 3.1) and no tie points, which limits that site to within-day comparisons of small zones and prevents testing Contrast D on 26 October. The chloride data are a single transect from a different year, measured with an ion-selective electrode whose stated accuracy ($\pm 15\%$ of reading or $\pm 5$ mg/L) is a substantial fraction of the concentrations measured, so only the larger differences along the transect, such as the 50 and 40 mg/L peaks against a background of about 14–25 mg/L, exceed it. The fault traces come from a county-scale map whose locations Budnik et al. describe as largely conjectural and for which no positional accuracy is stated, so we draw them as lines and cannot say how far a real fault lies from any mapped position. Zones contain three to eleven points, the autocorrelation of residuals is poorly determined, and the adjusted $p$-values are a sensitivity check. Finally, three fault contrasts in one lithology cannot support any general statement about faults.

### 4.5 A test design

The survey nonetheless suggests how the fault-conduit hypothesis could be tested. First, surveys should be completed within a single day, or tied across days by repeated points, under steady flow, because changing conditions between runs are a recognised source of error in synoptic profiles [33]. Our own Site 3 data show the cost: pooling the two survey days, which had no tie points, produces an apparent 18 $\mu$S/cm step at the second fault that is entirely the offset between days, and it becomes apparent only when the zone variances are examined. Second, paired discharge measurements would turn conductance into load and separate dilution from addition. Third, chloride-to-bromide ratios would fingerprint deicing salt against wastewater and other sources [29]. Fourth, environmental age tracers would indicate whether water entering near a fault is older groundwater [36]. Fifth, repeated cross-channel and depth readings would show whether small contrasts exceed lateral variation. Sixth, fault zones should be located in the field rather than from county maps. Seventh, surveys should cover several lithologies and many crossings, with change-point analysis applied to single-day transects so that gradual ramps and abrupt steps can be distinguished.

The design is meant to be falsifiable. If a fault routes road-salt groundwater to the stream, a single-day survey with discharge measurements should show an abrupt rise in conductance and chloride load at the crossing, not a ramp; chloride-to-bromide ratios in that water should resemble deicing salt, for which chloride-to-bromide ratios above 1,000 at chloride above 100 mg/L marked halite-dominated waters in the northern glacial-aquifer system [29], so the ratio would need careful interpretation at the 14–50 mg/L chloride we measured; and tracer ages of the discharging water should differ from those in neighbouring reaches. A diffuse or wastewater source predicts a gradual ramp, or an increase beginning at the facility, and a different ratio, since sewage mixtures are common at lower ratios. Where the crossing shows no step, no load increase, and ratios and ages like the neighbouring reaches, the hypothesis would not be supported for that fault. Applying the same tests at several faults would show whether any support generalises.

### 4.6 Management implications

Salt entering streams through groundwater will continue for years after application ceases, because of long groundwater transit times [40]. The evidence here does not justify changing deicing practice on the basis of fault locations. Mapped faults are at most a candidate screening layer, to be tested with the design above before any use in salt management, alongside the usual criteria of groundwater recharge areas, wetlands, shallow water tables and drinking-water sources [6]. Measures that reduce the total salt load, such as lower application rates, calibrated equipment, pre-wetting, brine-based anti-icing and staff training, as recommended by the Adirondack Road Salt Reduction Task Force [41], remain the better-supported response everywhere.

If the test design were to show that some mapped faults do deliver salt to streams, the screening layer could help to prioritise where to monitor and where to reduce application first; that is a prospect to evaluate, and it is not a finding of this study.

## 5 Conclusions

Do fault zones route road-salt-contaminated groundwater to streams? In this survey, not clearly. We compared specific conductance upstream and downstream of three mapped high-angle faults on Wappinger Creek, using within-day contrasts. One contrast (Site 2) shows a small, significant increase of 4.3 $\mu$S/cm, about 2.5 times the instrument's stated accuracy. It is a gradual rise that begins roughly 1.6 km upstream of the zone boundary, which marks the fault position we interpreted in the field at a channel bend, and two private wastewater plants beside that reach are an untested alternative explanation. A second fault shows no increase, and a third shows a rise within instrument accuracy. No conductance breakpoint on any transect coincides with a fault contrast boundary. The tributary contrast behaves as mixing predicts, so the survey detects a known input. A single chloride transect from 2020 peaks near a different fault, but on one sample, and shows no increase at Contrast E.

The survey also carries a methodological lesson. When the two Site 3 survey days are pooled, the second fault appears as the largest and most significant step (18.0 $\mu$S/cm), but that step is an artefact of the offset between the days (within one day the contrast is $+1.6$ $\mu$S/cm). Longitudinal surveys used to locate point inputs need single-day or tie-pointed sampling, effective sample sizes that allow for spatial autocorrelation, and analyses that distinguish gradual ramps from abrupt steps.

The contribution of the study is therefore a screening approach with a stated resolution, a documented pitfall, and a design for the test it could not complete, together with the hydrogeological case, drawn from studies of fault zones in fractured and metamorphic rock, for why faults remain a plausible pathway. It is not evidence that the pathway operates at Wappinger Creek.

We therefore treat the fault-conduit hypothesis as plausible from the hydrogeological literature but untested here. A conclusive test would combine single-day or tie-pointed synoptic surveys under steady flow, paired discharge measurements, chloride-to-bromide ratios, groundwater age tracers, repeated cross-channel and depth readings, field-located fault zones, and several lithologies. Until such a test exists, mapped fault locations should be regarded as a candidate screening layer to evaluate and not as a basis for changing deicing practice.

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## Conflict of interest

The authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

## Data Availability

Both the data, and the code, to reproduce figures and statistics from this paper are made available at the following GitHub Repository: `https://github.com/taddyb/wappingers_road_salts`. All individual specific-conductance measurements are also listed in Appendix A. Road and stream layers are from the US Census Bureau TIGER/Line 2024 files and the USGS National Hydrography Dataset, and wastewater facility locations are from EPA ECHO (retrieved 2026-11-08).

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# A Survey measurements

Table A1 lists every specific-conductance measurement from the 2018 survey: the field site and point number, the survey date, the along-channel distance from the upstream end of each single-day transect, the position, specific conductance (SC, $\mu$S/cm), water temperature ($T$, °C), the zone, and whether the point was flagged in the field log as lying just downstream of the mapped fault (Fault: yes). The flag records what we believed at the time of sampling and does not mark an observed fault position.

Table A1: All specific-conductance (SC) measurements, 28 September–26 October 2018 survey. Distance is along-channel from the upstream end of each single-day transect (haversine sum of GPS fixes).

| Site | Field | Pt | Date | Dist (m) | Lat | Lon | SC | $T$ | Zone | Fault |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 1 | 1 | 2018-09-28 | 0 | 41.80363 | -73.78189 | 258.9 | 15.3 | 1-1 | no |
| 1 | 1 | 2 | 2018-09-28 | 13 | 41.80370 | -73.78202 | 260.4 | 15.2 | 1-1 | no |
| 1 | 1 | 3 | 2018-09-28 | 200 | 41.80275 | -73.78388 | 260.0 | 15.2 | 1-1 | no |
| 1 | 1 | 4 | 2018-09-28 | 298 | 41.80314 | -73.78494 | 260.1 | 15.2 | 1-1 | no |
| 1 | 1 | 5 | 2018-09-28 | 428 | 41.80420 | -73.78561 | 259.5 | 15.2 | 1-2 | yes |
| 1 | 1 | 6 | 2018-09-28 | 514 | 41.80359 | -73.78623 | 259.5 | 15.2 | 1-2 | yes |
| 1 | 1 | 7 | 2018-09-28 | 592 | 41.80295 | -73.78663 | 259.4 | 15.2 | 1-2 | yes |
| 1 | 1 | 8 | 2018-09-28 | 649 | 41.80251 | -73.78697 | 259.4 | 15.2 | 1-2 | yes |
| 1 | 1 | 9 | 2018-09-28 | 677 | 41.80237 | -73.78726 | 259.2 | 15.2 | 1-2 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 1 | 2018-10-05 | 0 | 41.74113 | -73.83050 | 307.8 | 15.4 | 2-1 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 2 | 2018-10-05 | 563 | 41.73644 | -73.83305 | 307.9 | 15.4 | 2-1 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 3 | 2018-10-05 | 878 | 41.73422 | -73.83541 | 308.3 | 15.4 | 2-1 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 4 | 2018-10-05 | 1591 | 41.72798 | -73.83739 | 308.3 | 15.5 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 5 | 2018-10-05 | 1995 | 41.72470 | -73.83949 | 308.7 | 15.6 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 6 | 2018-10-05 | 2362 | 41.72140 | -73.83969 | 307.3 | 15.5 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 7 | 2018-10-05 | 2872 | 41.71792 | -73.84369 | 309.5 | 15.6 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 8 | 2018-10-05 | 3240 | 41.71499 | -73.84574 | 309.3 | 15.6 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 9 | 2018-10-05 | 3357 | 41.71397 | -73.84609 | 309.7 | 15.6 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 10 | 2018-10-05 | 3820 | 41.71455 | -73.85161 | 311.1 | 15.7 | 2-1 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 11 | 2018-10-05 | 4166 | 41.71193 | -73.85387 | 310.8 | 15.7 | 2-2 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 12 | 2018-10-05 | 4540 | 41.70899 | -73.85606 | 311.4 | 15.7 | 2-2 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 13 | 2018-10-05 | 4836 | 41.70650 | -73.85732 | 311.9 | 15.8 | 2-2 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 14 | 2018-10-05 | 5335 | 41.70284 | -73.86080 | 312.7 | 15.8 | 2-2 | no |

| Site | Field | Pt | Date | Dist (m) | Lat | Lon | SC | $T$ | Zone | Fault |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | 2 | 15 | 2018-10-05 | 5704 | 41.69994 | -73.86296 | 312.6 | 15.8 | 2-2 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 16 | 2018-10-05 | 6191 | 41.69676 | -73.86699 | 313.5 | 15.7 | 2-2 | yes |
| 2 | 2 | 17 | 2018-10-05 | 6582 | 41.69324 | -73.86698 | 316.0 | 15.8 | 2-2 | no |
| 2 | 2 | 18 | 2018-10-05 | 7066 | 41.68951 | -73.86997 | 315.7 | 15.8 | 2-2 | yes |
| 3 | 3 | 1 | 2018-10-19 | 0 | 41.79652 | -73.71534 | 340.5 | 9.4 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 2 | 2018-10-19 | 61 | 41.79607 | -73.71577 | 340.2 | 9.4 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 3 | 2018-10-19 | 133 | 41.79582 | -73.71656 | 340.1 | 9.5 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 4 | 2018-10-19 | 233 | 41.79613 | -73.71770 | 340.5 | 9.5 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 5 | 2018-10-19 | 319 | 41.79673 | -73.71835 | 339.8 | 9.6 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 6 | 2018-10-19 | 368 | 41.79674 | -73.71894 | 339.4 | 9.5 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 7 | 2018-10-19 | 471 | 41.79639 | -73.72009 | 338.8 | 9.6 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 8 | 2018-10-19 | 789 | 41.79467 | -73.72316 | 334.8 | 9.7 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 9 | 2018-10-19 | 872 | 41.79394 | -73.72337 | 335.2 | 9.7 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 10 | 2018-10-19 | 973 | 41.79374 | -73.72455 | 336.9 | 9.7 | 3-3 | yes |
| 3 | 3 | 11 | 2018-10-19 | 1056 | 41.79331 | -73.72537 | 336.1 | 9.7 | 3-3 | yes |
| 3 | 3 | 12 | 2018-10-19 | 1175 | 41.79251 | -73.72633 | 335.9 | 9.8 | 3-3 | yes |
| 3 | 3 | 13 | 2018-10-19 | 1322 | 41.79155 | -73.72755 | 332.7 | 10.0 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 14 | 2018-10-19 | 1479 | 41.79168 | -73.72944 | 333.2 | 10.0 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 15 | 2018-10-19 | 1590 | 41.79136 | -73.73070 | 333.2 | 10.0 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 16 | 2018-10-19 | 1706 | 41.79091 | -73.73196 | 331.4 | 10.0 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 17 | 2018-10-19 | 1771 | 41.79048 | -73.73142 | 332.5 | 10.1 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 18 | 2018-10-19 | 1881 | 41.78949 | -73.73137 | 332.2 | 10.1 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 19 | 2018-10-19 | 2034 | 41.78819 | -73.73197 | 331.8 | 10.2 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 3 | 20 | 2018-10-19 | 2130 | 41.78765 | -73.73287 | 332.0 | 10.2 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 14 | 2018-10-26 | 0 | 41.79600 | -73.71273 | 375.2 | 8.7 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 13 | 2018-10-26 | 83 | 41.79581 | -73.71370 | 374.0 | 8.7 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 12 | 2018-10-26 | 154 | 41.79640 | -73.71401 | 374.1 | 8.7 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 11 | 2018-10-26 | 254 | 41.79660 | -73.71519 | 369.8 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 10 | 2018-10-26 | 309 | 41.79614 | -73.71543 | 369.7 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 9 | 2018-10-26 | 394 | 41.79573 | -73.71630 | 369.8 | 8.7 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 8 | 2018-10-26 | 428 | 41.79556 | -73.71664 | 369.8 | 8.7 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 7 | 2018-10-26 | 507 | 41.79607 | -73.71730 | 369.2 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 6 | 2018-10-26 | 583 | 41.79652 | -73.71799 | 369.1 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 5 | 2018-10-26 | 658 | 41.79688 | -73.71876 | 367.8 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 4 | 2018-10-26 | 714 | 41.79656 | -73.71928 | 367.4 | 8.8 | 3-1 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 3 | 2018-10-26 | 831 | 41.79620 | -73.72061 | 366.1 | 8.7 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 2 | 2018-10-26 | 972 | 41.79515 | -73.72156 | 364.8 | 8.8 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 5 | 1 | 2018-10-26 | 1077 | 41.79478 | -73.72272 | 363.9 | 8.9 | 3-2 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 1 | 2018-10-26 | 0 | 41.78772 | -73.73268 | 355.5 | 8.3 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 2 | 2018-10-26 | 80 | 41.78704 | -73.73298 | 358.2 | 8.2 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 3 | 2018-10-26 | 188 | 41.78674 | -73.73423 | 359.7 | 8.2 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 4 | 2018-10-26 | 343 | 41.78550 | -73.73508 | 359.7 | 8.1 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 5 | 2018-10-26 | 520 | 41.78416 | -73.73623 | 360.2 | 8.1 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 6 | 2018-10-26 | 628 | 41.78364 | -73.73732 | 359.6 | 8.2 | 3-3 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 7 | 2018-10-26 | 804 | 41.78239 | -73.73864 | 361.5 | 8.1 | 3-4 | yes |
| 3 | 4 | 8 | 2018-10-26 | 930 | 41.78302 | -73.73989 | 360.9 | 8.1 | 3-4 | yes |
| 3 | 4 | 9 | 2018-10-26 | 1099 | 41.78305 | -73.74193 | 359.3 | 8.3 | 3-4 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 10 | 2018-10-26 | 1153 | 41.78323 | -73.74254 | 360.2 | 8.3 | 3-4 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 11 | 2018-10-26 | 1269 | 41.78308 | -73.74392 | 359.7 | 8.4 | 3-4 | no |
| 3 | 4 | 12 | 2018-10-26 | 1299 | 41.78325 | -73.74421 | 360.6 | 8.3 | 3-4 | no |